

Aetna Coverage Comparison Guide

Plan Year 2024-2025 Document Reference: w14_aetna_ccg_2024 **Effective Date:** January 1, 2024

> **Related Documents:** > This Coverage Comparison Guide should be read in conjunction with the following Aetna plan documents: > > - **Summary of Benefits and Coverage (SBC):** Document w14_aetna_sbc_008 -- Key sections: **Coverage Overview, Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits, Common Medical Events** > - **Member Handbook:** Document w14_aetna_member_handbook_012 -- Key sections: **Welcome and Plan Overview, How Your Plan Works, Understanding Your Costs** > - **Formulary Guide:** Document w14_aetna_formulary_009 -- Key sections: **Tier Structure and Cost Sharing, Generic Medications (Tier 1-2), Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)**

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Section 1: Plan Tier Overview

1.1 Introduction to Aetna's Plan Tiers

Aetna offers a structured portfolio of health insurance plans designed to meet the diverse needs of individuals, families, and employer groups. Each plan tier represents a distinct balance between monthly premium costs and out-of-pocket expenses at the point of care. Understanding the differences among these tiers is the first step toward selecting the plan that best fits your health profile, financial situation, and anticipated care needs.

For the 2024-2025 plan year, Aetna presents four core plan tiers under its commercial portfolio: **Bronze, Silver, Gold, and Platinum**. These tiers align with the Affordable Care Act's metallic tier framework and are designed to provide progressively richer benefit structures as the tier level increases. Members who expect higher utilization of medical services -- including specialist visits, prescription medications, and hospital stays -- will generally find greater value in higher-tier plans, while members who are generally healthy and seek primarily catastrophic coverage may prefer the lower-cost Bronze tier.

All four tiers share a common network infrastructure built on Aetna's broad PPO network, giving members access to more than 1.2 million healthcare professionals and over 5,700 hospitals nationwide. Out-of-network services are available on all tiers, though cost-sharing differences between in-network and out-of-network care are significant and are detailed throughout this guide.

This section provides a high-level overview of each tier's structure, premium ranges, and key cost-sharing features. For complete benefit details, please refer to document w14_aetna_sbc_008,

specifically the sections titled **Coverage Overview, Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits, and Common Medical Events.**

1.2 Plan Tier Summary Table

The table below provides a consolidated overview of the four plan tiers available for the 2024-2025 plan year. All figures represent individual coverage unless otherwise noted. Family coverage amounts are generally two times the individual amounts for deductibles and out-of-pocket maximums, subject to embedded deductible rules.

Feature	Bronze Plan	Silver Plan	Gold Plan	Platinum Plan
Monthly Premium (Individual, Est.)	\$285-\$340	\$420-\$490	\$560-\$640	\$720-\$810
In-Network Deductible	\$5,000	\$2,000	\$1,000	\$500
Out-of-Pocket Maximum (In-Network)	\$9,100	\$7,500	\$5,500	\$3,500
Coinsurance (After Deductible)	40% member	20% member	15% member	10% member
Primary Care Copay	\$75	\$40	\$30	\$20
Specialist Copay	\$110	\$75	\$60	\$40
Emergency Room Copay	\$500	\$300	\$250	\$200
Generic Drug Copay (Tier 1)	\$20	\$15	\$10	\$5
Out-of-Network Coverage	40% after \$8,000 ded.	50% after \$4,000 deductible	60% after \$3,000 ded.	70% after \$2,000 ded.
Actuarial Value (Approx.)	60%	70%	80%	90%

> **Note:** Premium estimates are based on a 40-year-old non-tobacco user residing in a standard rating area. Actual premiums will vary based on age, tobacco use, geographic rating area, and employer contribution levels. Please consult your benefits administrator or Aetna representative for personalized premium quotes.

1.3 The Silver Plan -- Featured Tier

The **Silver Plan** is the most commonly selected tier among Aetna members and serves as the benchmark plan under ACA marketplace guidelines. It strikes a balance between affordable monthly premiums and manageable cost-sharing at the point of care, making it appropriate for a broad range of

members.

The Silver Plan features an **in-network deductible of \$2,000** for individual coverage, after which the plan pays 80% of covered services and the member pays 20% coinsurance. The **out-of-pocket maximum is \$7,500** for individual in-network coverage, ensuring that no member will pay more than this amount in a given plan year for covered services rendered by in-network providers.

The Silver Plan's **emergency room copay is \$300** per visit. This copay applies after the deductible has been satisfied; if the deductible has not yet been met, emergency room charges apply toward the deductible and then the copay structure takes effect for subsequent visits.

For mental and behavioral health services, the Silver Plan provides **Unlimited, \$50 copay** per visit for outpatient mental health therapy, psychiatry, and substance use disorder counseling. This parity-compliant benefit applies equally to in-network behavioral health providers and is not subject to visit limits.

There is **no pre-existing condition waiting period** under any Aetna plan offered in this portfolio. Coverage for pre-existing conditions begins on the member's effective date of coverage, consistent with federal requirements under the Affordable Care Act. The value **None** applies across all four tiers for the pre-existing condition waiting period.

For imaging services such as MRIs and CT scans, **prior authorization is Required, with a 3-day turnaround** for standard (non-urgent) requests. Urgent prior authorization requests are processed within 24 hours. Members or their providers should initiate the prior authorization process through Aetna's provider portal or by calling the Member Services line listed on the back of the member ID card.

1.4 Prescription Drug Benefit Structure

Aetna's prescription drug benefit is organized into **5 tiers** across all plan levels. This tiered formulary structure allows members to make informed choices about their medications and understand the cost implications of brand-name versus generic alternatives. The five-tier structure is consistent across the Bronze, Silver, Gold, and Platinum plans, though the specific copay and coinsurance amounts differ by tier.

For a comprehensive listing of covered medications, cost-sharing amounts, and prior authorization requirements by drug, members should consult document **w14_aetna_formulary_009**, particularly the sections **Tier Structure and Cost Sharing, Generic Medications (Tier 1-2), and Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)**.

Drug Tier	Tier Name	Description	Silver Plan Cost-Share
Tier 1	Preferred Generic	Low-cost generic medications	\$15 copay
Tier 2	Non-Preferred Generic	Generic medications not on preferred list	\$30 copay
Tier 3	Preferred Brand	Brand-name medications with preferred status	\$60 copay

Tier 4	Non-Preferred Brand / Specialty	High-cost brand and specialty medications	\$100 copay or 25% coinsurance
Tier 5	Ultra-Specialty	Biologic and very high-cost specialty drugs	30% coinsurance (subject to specialty maximum)

1.5 Network and Access Overview

All plans in this portfolio are built on Aetna's Choice POS II network, which provides both in-network and out-of-network benefits without requiring a referral to see a specialist. Members are encouraged to use in-network providers to minimize their out-of-pocket costs. The **out-of-network coverage** structure varies by plan tier (see Section 1.2 table), with the Silver Plan providing **50% after \$4,000 deductible** for covered out-of-network services.

Members seeking additional detail on how the plan network operates, including rules for continuity of care, standing referrals, and out-of-area urgent care, should review document **w14_aetna_member_handbook_012**, specifically the sections **Welcome and Plan Overview, How Your Plan Works, and Understanding Your Costs**.

Section 2: Side-by-Side Coverage Comparison

2.1 Overview of This Section

This section provides a detailed, benefit-by-benefit comparison of Aetna's four plan tiers. The tables and narrative in this section are designed to help members and benefits administrators evaluate coverage differences across specific categories of care, including preventive services, outpatient care, inpatient hospitalization, emergency services, behavioral health, maternity, and prescription drugs.

All comparisons reflect in-network benefits unless explicitly noted as out-of-network. Cost-sharing amounts are for individual coverage. For family cost-sharing rules, including embedded versus aggregate deductible structures, please consult document **w14_aetna_member_handbook_012**, section **Understanding Your Costs**.

2.2 Preventive and Wellness Services

Preventive care services are covered at **100% with no cost-sharing** across all four plan tiers when rendered by an in-network provider. This applies to services rated "A" or "B" by the U.S. Preventive Services Task Force (USPSTF), as well as immunizations recommended by the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices (ACIP) and preventive care for women as recommended by the Health Resources and Services Administration (HRSA).

Preventive Service	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
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Annual Wellness Exam	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Routine Blood Work (Preventive)	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Mammogram (Screening)	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Colonoscopy (Screening)	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Childhood Immunizations	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Flu Shot (Annual)	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Well-Woman Exam	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
Tobacco Cessation Counseling	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0

> **Important:** If a preventive visit includes diagnostic services or the provider bills the encounter as a diagnostic visit rather than a preventive visit, cost-sharing may apply. Members should confirm the billing code with their provider prior to the visit. CPT code 99395 (preventive medicine, established patient, 18-39 years) and CPT code 99396 (40-64 years) are the standard codes for preventive exams.

2.3 Outpatient Care Comparison

Service	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Primary Care Visit (In-Network)	\$75 copay	\$40 copay	\$30 copay	\$20 copay
Specialist Visit (In-Network)	\$110 copay	\$75 copay	\$60 copay	\$40 copay
Urgent Care (In-Network)	\$90 copay	\$65 copay	\$50 copay	\$35 copay
Lab Work (Diagnostic)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
X-Ray (Diagnostic)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
MRI / CT Scan	40% after ded. + PA req.	20% after ded. + PA req.	15% after ded. + PA req.	10% after ded. + PA req.
Physical Therapy (Per Visit)	\$75 copay	\$55 copay	\$45 copay	\$30 copay
Occupational Therapy (Per Visit)	\$75 copay	\$55 copay	\$45 copay	\$30 copay

Chiropractic Care (Per Visit, up to 30/yr)	\$75 copay	\$55 copay	\$45 copay	\$30 copay
Outpatient Surgery (Facility)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Outpatient Surgery (Professional)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.

Prior Authorization for Imaging: For all plan tiers, MRI and CT scan services require prior authorization. The standard processing time is **Required, 3-day turnaround** for non-urgent requests. Failure to obtain prior authorization may result in a reduction of benefits or denial of the claim. Members are advised to confirm prior authorization status with their provider before scheduling imaging appointments.

2.4 Inpatient Hospital Services

Service	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Inpatient Hospitalization (Per Admission)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Inpatient Physician Fees	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Skilled Nursing Facility (Days 1-60)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Skilled Nursing Facility (Days 61-90)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Inpatient Rehabilitation	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Inpatient Mental Health / Substance Use	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Maternity -- Delivery (Hospital)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Newborn Care (In-Hospital)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.

> **Pre-Notification Requirement:** Inpatient admissions (non-emergency) require pre-notification at least 5 business days prior to the planned admission date. Emergency admissions must be reported to Aetna within 48 hours of admission. Failure to provide timely notification may result in a \$500 non-notification penalty applied to the member's cost-sharing obligation.

2.5 Emergency and Urgent Care

Service	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Emergency Room (In-Network)	\$500 copay	\$300 copay	\$250 copay	\$200 copay
Emergency Room (Out-of-Network)	\$500 copay	\$300 copay	\$250 copay	\$200 copay
Emergency Physician Fee	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Ambulance (Ground)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Ambulance (Air)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Urgent Care (In-Network)	\$90 copay	\$65 copay	\$50 copay	\$35 copay
Urgent Care (Out-of-Network)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.

Emergency Room Copay Note: The emergency room copay is waived if the member is admitted to the hospital directly from the emergency room. In such cases, the inpatient hospitalization benefit applies. For the Silver Plan, the **er_copay is \$300** per visit. This copay applies regardless of whether the visit occurs at an in-network or out-of-network emergency facility, consistent with federal surprise billing protections under the No Surprises Act.

2.6 Behavioral Health and Mental Health Services

Aetna complies fully with the Mental Health Parity and Addiction Equity Act (MHPAEA), ensuring that mental health and substance use disorder benefits are no more restrictive than comparable medical and surgical benefits.

Service	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Outpatient Mental Health (Individual Therapy)	Unlimited, \$50 copay	Unlimited, \$50 copay	Unlimited, \$40 copay	Unlimited, \$25 copay
Outpatient Psychiatry Visit	\$110 copay	\$75 copay	\$60 copay	\$40 copay
Group Therapy	\$40 copay	\$30 copay	\$25 copay	\$15 copay
Intensive Outpatient Program (IOP)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.

Partial Hospitalization Program (PHP)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Inpatient Mental Health	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.
Substance Use Disorder (Outpatient)	Unlimited, \$50 copay	Unlimited, \$50 copay	Unlimited, \$40 copay	Unlimited, \$25 copay
Substance Use Disorder (Inpatient)	40% after ded.	20% after ded.	15% after ded.	10% after ded.

For the Silver Plan specifically, outpatient mental health therapy and substance use disorder counseling are covered at **Unlimited, \$50 copay** per visit. There is no annual visit limit, no lifetime limit, and no step-therapy requirement for accessing outpatient behavioral health services.

2.7 Prescription Drug Coverage Comparison

All plans utilize Aetna's **5 tiers** formulary structure. The formulary is updated quarterly. Members are encouraged to verify their medications' tier status before the plan year begins and whenever a new medication is prescribed. For detailed formulary information, refer to document **w14_aetna_formulary_009**, sections **Tier Structure and Cost Sharing, Generic Medications (Tier 1-2), and Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)**.

Tier	Tier Name	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Tier 1	Preferred Generic	\$20 copay	\$15 copay	\$10 copay	\$5 copay
Tier 2	Non-Preferred Generic	\$40 copay	\$30 copay	\$20 copay	\$10 copay
Tier 3	Preferred Brand	\$80 copay	\$60 copay	\$50 copay	\$35 copay
Tier 4	Non-Preferred Brand / Specialty	35% coinsurance	25% coinsurance	20% coinsurance	15% coinsurance
Tier 5	Ultra-Specialty	40% coinsurance	30% coinsurance	25% coinsurance	20% coinsurance
Mail Order (90-day supply, Tier 1)	\$45	\$35	\$25	\$10	
Mail Order (90-day supply, Tier 2)	\$90	\$70	\$50	\$25	

Annual Specialty Maximum (Tiers 4-5)	\$5,000	\$4,500	\$3,500	\$2,500	
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2.8 Pre-Existing Conditions and Waiting Periods

Under all Aetna plans in this portfolio, the pre-existing condition waiting period is **None**. Coverage for conditions that existed prior to the member's enrollment date begins immediately upon the effective date of coverage. This applies to all four plan tiers -- Bronze, Silver, Gold, and Platinum -- and to all covered services, including prescription drugs, specialist care, and surgical procedures related to pre-existing conditions.

This benefit is consistent with the requirements of the Affordable Care Act (ACA) and applies to all members regardless of age, health status, or prior coverage history.

2.9 Out-of-Network Benefits Summary

Feature	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Out-of-Network Deductible (Individual)	\$8,000	\$4,000	\$3,000	\$2,000
Out-of-Network Coinsurance (Member Pays)	60%	50%	40%	30%
Out-of-Network Out-of-Pocket Max	\$18,200	\$15,000	\$11,000	\$7,000
Balance Billing Protections	Yes (federal NSA)	Yes (federal NSA)	Yes (federal NSA)	Yes (federal NSA)

For the Silver Plan, out-of-network coverage is **50% after \$4,000 deductible**. This means that once a member has paid \$4,000 in out-of-network eligible expenses, the plan will cover 50% of the allowed amount for covered out-of-network services for the remainder of the plan year. Members are responsible for any balance billing amounts above Aetna's allowed charge, except where prohibited by the No Surprises Act.

Section 3: Cost Scenario Analysis

3.1 Introduction to Cost Scenarios

Understanding how a health plan performs in real-world situations is essential to making an informed enrollment decision. This section presents five illustrative cost scenarios representing different health utilization profiles. Each scenario calculates the estimated annual member cost-sharing under each of the four plan tiers, combining premiums and out-of-pocket expenses.

These scenarios are hypothetical and are intended for comparative purposes only. Actual costs will vary based on the member's specific utilization, provider network status, negotiated rates, and geographic location. For a full explanation of how cost-sharing is calculated, including the interaction between deductibles, copays, coinsurance, and out-of-pocket maximums, please review document [w14_aetna_member_handbook_012](#), section **Understanding Your Costs**.

3.2 Scenario A: Healthy Adult -- Minimal Utilization

Profile: 32-year-old individual in good health. Utilizes one annual preventive exam, two primary care visits for minor illness, and one generic prescription medication (Tier 1) taken daily for 12 months.

Assumed Annual Services:

- 1 Annual Wellness Exam (preventive, \$0 cost-share all tiers)
- 2 Primary Care Visits
- 12 months of Tier 1 generic prescription (monthly fill)

Cost Component	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Annual Premium	\$3,660	\$5,400	\$7,080	\$8,880
Preventive Exam	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0
2 Primary Care Visits	\$150	\$80	\$60	\$40
12 x Tier 1 Rx (\$20/\$15/\$10/\$5)	\$240	\$180	\$120	\$60
Total Annual Cost	\$4,050	\$5,660	\$7,260	\$8,980
Deductible Applied	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0

Analysis: For a healthy adult with minimal healthcare utilization, the Bronze Plan results in the lowest total annual cost despite its higher cost-sharing structure, because the member rarely needs to access the plan's deeper benefits. The premium savings of approximately \$1,740 per year compared to the Silver Plan more than offset the marginally higher copays for the two primary care visits.

Recommendation: Bronze or Silver. Bronze offers lowest total cost; Silver provides a better safety net if unexpected illness or injury occurs during the year.

3.3 Scenario B: Moderate Utilizer -- Chronic Condition Management

Profile: 45-year-old individual managing Type 2 Diabetes (ICD-10: E11.9) and hypertension (ICD-10: I10). Requires quarterly specialist visits (endocrinologist), monthly Tier 2 generic medications (metformin, lisinopril), one annual HbA1c lab panel, one annual diabetic eye exam, and one diagnostic MRI (lumbar spine, CPT: 72148) following a back injury.

Assumed Annual Services:

- 4 Specialist Visits (endocrinologist)
- 12 months of Tier 2 generic medications (2 drugs x 12 fills = 24 fills)
- 1 Diagnostic Lab Panel (HbA1c + comprehensive metabolic panel)
- 1 Diabetic Eye Exam (CPT: 92002)
- 1 MRI -- Lumbar Spine (CPT: 72148, prior authorization required)

Estimated Allowed Amounts (In-Network):

- Specialist Visit: \$250 allowed per visit
- Tier 2 Generic (per fill): \$30 allowed
- Diagnostic Lab Panel: \$180 allowed
- Diabetic Eye Exam: \$175 allowed
- MRI Lumbar Spine: \$1,400 allowed

Cost Component	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Annual Premium	\$3,660	\$5,400	\$7,080	\$8,880
4 Specialist Visits (copay)	\$440	\$300	\$240	\$160
24 Tier 2 Rx Fills	\$960	\$720	\$480	\$240
Diagnostic Lab Panel	\$180*	\$180*	\$180*	\$180*
Diabetic Eye Exam	\$175*	\$175*	\$175*	\$175*
MRI (after deductible met)	\$560**	\$280**	\$210**	\$140**
Total Out-of-Pocket (Non-Premium)	\$2,315	\$1,655	\$1,285	\$895
Total Annual Cost	\$5,975	\$7,055	\$8,365	\$9,775

*Diagnostic lab and eye exam costs reflect deductible application. Under Bronze, member pays full allowed amount until deductible met; amounts shown reflect post-deductible status after specialist visits and Rx fills have partially satisfied the deductible. **MRI cost reflects 40%/20%/15%/10% coinsurance applied to \$1,400 allowed amount after deductible satisfaction.

Note on MRI Prior Authorization: The lumbar spine MRI (CPT: 72148) requires prior authorization under all plan tiers. The standard turnaround is **Required, 3-day turnaround** for non-urgent requests. Members should plan accordingly when scheduling this service.

Analysis: At this utilization level, the Silver Plan begins to demonstrate its value over the Bronze Plan. The member's total annual cost under Silver (\$7,055) is approximately \$1,080 higher than Bronze (\$5,975), but the Silver Plan's lower deductible of **\$2,000** (versus \$5,000 for Bronze) means the member reaches cost-sharing relief much sooner in the plan year. If utilization increases -- for example, if the member requires additional specialist visits or a hospitalization -- the Silver Plan's advantage grows substantially.

Recommendation: Silver or Gold. The Silver Plan's **out-of-pocket maximum of \$7,500** provides meaningful financial protection for members managing chronic conditions, while its premium remains significantly lower than the Gold and Platinum tiers.

3.4 Scenario C: High Utilizer -- Major Medical Event

Profile: 52-year-old individual who experiences a cardiac event requiring emergency room visit, inpatient hospitalization (4 days), cardiac catheterization, and follow-up care including 6 cardiology visits, cardiac rehabilitation (20 sessions), and ongoing Tier 3 and Tier 4 prescription medications.

Estimated Allowed Amounts (In-Network):

- Emergency Room Visit: \$3,500 (facility) + \$800 (physician)
- Inpatient Hospitalization (4 days): \$28,000
- Cardiac Catheterization (CPT: 93458): \$8,500
- 6 Cardiology Specialist Visits: \$250 each = \$1,500 total
- 20 Cardiac Rehabilitation Sessions (CPT: 93798): \$150 each = \$3,000 total
- Tier 3 Medication (12 fills): \$720 total allowed
- Tier 4 Medication (12 fills): \$3,600 total allowed

Total Allowed Charges: \$50,620

Cost Component	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Annual Premium	\$3,660	\$5,400	\$7,080	\$8,880
In-Network Out-of-Pocket (Capped at OOP Max)	\$9,100	\$7,500	\$5,500	\$3,500
Total Annual Cost (Premium + OOP Max)	\$12,760	\$12,900	\$12,580	\$12,380

Analysis: In a catastrophic utilization scenario, all four plans reach their respective out-of-pocket maximums. The total annual cost (premium plus out-of-pocket maximum) is remarkably similar across tiers, ranging from \$12,380 (Platinum) to \$12,900 (Silver). However, the **timing** of when the out-of-pocket maximum is reached differs significantly. Under the Platinum Plan, the member reaches the \$3,500 out-of-pocket maximum much earlier in the plan year, while under the Bronze Plan, the member may face the full \$9,100 out-of-pocket maximum before relief kicks in.

The **Silver Plan's out-of-pocket maximum of \$7,500** represents a meaningful ceiling on financial exposure. For members who anticipate the possibility of a major medical event, the Gold or Platinum plans offer lower total exposure when factoring in the cash flow impact of paying higher out-of-pocket costs earlier in the year.

Emergency Room Copay: In this scenario, the **er_copay of \$300** (Silver Plan) is waived because the member was admitted to the hospital directly from the emergency room. The inpatient benefit applies from the point of admission.

3.5 Scenario D: Family Coverage -- Mixed Utilization

Profile: Family of four (two adults, two children). One adult manages a chronic condition; one child has asthma requiring regular specialist visits and prescription medications; the other adult and child are generally healthy.

This scenario illustrates the family out-of-pocket maximum and embedded deductible structure. Under the Silver Plan, the family in-network deductible is \$4,000 (2x individual), and the family out-of-pocket maximum is \$15,000 (2x individual). However, no single family member is required to satisfy more than the individual deductible of **\$2,000** before their claims are processed at the post-deductible coinsurance rate.

Family Member	Annual Allowed Charges	Estimated OOP (Silver)
Adult 1 (Chronic Condition)	\$18,500	\$3,200 (approaches individual OOP max)
Adult 2 (Healthy)	\$2,800	\$640
Child 1 (Asthma)	\$9,400	\$2,800
Child 2 (Healthy)	\$1,200	\$280
Family Total	\$31,900	\$6,920

Annual Premium (Family, Silver): \$13,440 (estimated) **Total Annual Family Cost:** \$6,920 (OOP) + \$13,440 (premium) = **\$20,360**

Analysis: The embedded deductible structure of the Silver Plan benefits families where one or more members have significantly higher utilization than others. Each family member's costs are tracked individually against the \$2,000 individual deductible, preventing any single member from being required to satisfy the full \$4,000 family deductible before receiving cost-sharing benefits.

3.6 Scenario E: Out-of-Network Utilization

Profile: 38-year-old member who receives care from an out-of-network specialist (orthopedic surgeon) for a knee replacement surgery. Total allowed charges for out-of-network services: \$45,000.

Under the Silver Plan, **out-of-network coverage is 50% after \$4,000 deductible**. Once the member satisfies the \$4,000 out-of-network deductible, the plan pays 50% of the allowed amount and the member pays 50% coinsurance, up to the out-of-network out-of-pocket maximum of \$15,000.

Cost Component	Silver Plan (Out-of-Network)
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Out-of-Network Deductible	\$4,000
Remaining Allowed Charges	\$41,000
Member Coinsurance (50% of \$41,000)	\$20,500
Out-of-Network OOP Maximum	\$15,000
Member Pays (Capped at OOP Max)	\$15,000
Plan Pays (After OOP Max Reached)	\$30,000
Potential Balance Billing (Above Allowed Amount)	Varies by provider
Annual Premium	\$5,400
Total Member Cost (Premium + OOP)	\$20,400

Important: Members are strongly encouraged to use in-network providers whenever possible. The difference in total annual cost between in-network and out-of-network care for a major procedure can exceed \$7,500 in additional out-of-pocket expenses, not including potential balance billing.

Section 4: Choosing the Right Plan

4.1 A Framework for Plan Selection

Selecting the right health insurance plan is one of the most consequential financial decisions a member can make each year. The "right" plan is not necessarily the one with the lowest premium or the most comprehensive coverage -- it is the plan that best aligns with your expected healthcare utilization, financial circumstances, risk tolerance, and personal priorities.

Aetna's four-tier portfolio is designed to accommodate a wide spectrum of member needs. This section provides a structured framework to guide your decision, including a self-assessment tool, plan-specific recommendations, and guidance on special circumstances such as Health Savings Account (HSA) eligibility, dependent coverage, and anticipated life changes.

For additional guidance on understanding your plan options and how benefits work in practice, members are encouraged to review document [w14_aetna_member_handbook_012](#), particularly the sections **Welcome and Plan Overview** and **How Your Plan Works**, which provide detailed explanations of network access, claims processing, and member rights.

4.2 Step 1 -- Assess Your Health Utilization Profile

The first step in choosing a plan is to honestly assess how much healthcare you and your covered dependents typically use in a year. Consider the following categories:

Category 1: Low Utilization You visit a doctor fewer than three times per year, take no regular prescription medications or only low-cost generics, have no chronic conditions requiring ongoing management, and have no planned surgeries or procedures. You are primarily seeking coverage for unexpected catastrophic events.

*Best Match: **Bronze Plan*** -- Lowest premium, highest deductible. Appropriate if you can absorb up to \$9,100 in out-of-pocket costs in the event of a significant medical event. Consider pairing with a Health Savings Account (HSA) to build a tax-advantaged reserve for future medical expenses (see Section 4.5).

Category 2: Moderate Utilization You visit a primary care physician 3-6 times per year, see one or two specialists annually, take one or more regular prescription medications (generic or low-cost brand), and may have a chronic condition that is well-controlled. You do not anticipate hospitalization but want reasonable protection against unexpected illness or injury.

*Best Match: **Silver Plan*** -- The Silver Plan's **in-network deductible of \$2,000** and **out-of-pocket maximum of \$7,500** provide a strong balance of premium affordability and financial protection. The Silver Plan is the most widely selected tier among Aetna members for this reason.

Category 3: High Utilization You have one or more chronic conditions requiring frequent specialist visits, take multiple prescription medications including brand-name or specialty drugs, have had or anticipate having a hospitalization or significant surgical procedure, or are pregnant or planning a pregnancy.

*Best Match: **Gold Plan*** -- The Gold Plan's lower deductible (\$1,000), lower coinsurance (15%), and lower out-of-pocket maximum (\$5,500) reduce the financial burden of high healthcare utilization. While the premium is higher than Silver, the total annual cost is often lower for high utilizers (see Scenario C in Section 3).

Category 4: Very High Utilization / Complex Medical Needs You require frequent hospitalizations, complex specialty care, multiple high-cost specialty medications, or ongoing intensive medical management. Cost predictability and minimizing out-of-pocket expenses at the point of care are your highest priorities.

*Best Match: **Platinum Plan*** -- The Platinum Plan's \$500 deductible, 10% coinsurance, and \$3,500 out-of-pocket maximum provide the highest level of financial protection. The premium is the highest of the four tiers, but for members with very high utilization, the Platinum Plan typically results in the lowest total annual cost when premium and out-of-pocket expenses are combined.

4.3 Step 2 -- Consider Your Financial Risk Tolerance

Beyond utilization, your financial situation plays a critical role in plan selection. Consider the following questions:

Can you afford a large unexpected medical bill? If a \$5,000 or \$9,000 medical bill would cause significant financial hardship, a lower-deductible plan (Gold or Platinum) may be worth the higher premium even if you don't use much healthcare. The Bronze Plan's \$5,000 deductible means you could pay this amount before the plan's coinsurance kicks in for most services.

Do you have savings set aside for medical expenses? Members who have substantial savings or who are contributing to an HSA may be better positioned to absorb the higher cost-sharing of the Bronze Plan in exchange for lower premiums. The Bronze Plan is the only tier that qualifies as a High Deductible Health Plan (HDHP) under IRS guidelines, making it HSA-eligible (see Section 4.5).

Is your income stable and predictable? Members with variable income may prefer the predictability of a higher-premium, lower-cost-sharing plan (Gold or Platinum) to avoid large unexpected medical bills in months when cash flow is constrained.

Do you have dependents with significant health needs? When covering a family, the financial risk of a high-deductible plan is magnified. A child with asthma, a spouse managing a chronic illness, or a planned pregnancy can quickly push a family's out-of-pocket costs toward the maximum under a Bronze or Silver plan. In these circumstances, Gold or Platinum coverage may offer better overall value.

4.4 Step 3 -- Evaluate Your Prescription Drug Needs

Prescription drug costs are one of the most significant drivers of healthcare spending for many members. Aetna's **5 tiers** formulary structure means that the tier placement of your medications has a direct and substantial impact on your annual drug costs.

Before selecting a plan, take the following steps:

1. **List all current medications** -- Include the drug name, dosage, and frequency for each medication you and your covered dependents take regularly.

1. **Check the formulary** -- Verify that your medications are covered under the Aetna formulary and identify their tier placement. Use Aetna's online formulary search tool or consult document **w14_aetna_formulary_009**, sections **Tier Structure and Cost Sharing**, **Generic Medications (Tier 1-2)**, and **Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)** for detailed information.

1. **Calculate your annual drug costs under each plan** -- Multiply the per-fill copay by the number of fills you expect per year. Don't forget to account for mail-order savings if you take maintenance medications.

1. **Ask about generic alternatives** -- If any of your medications are Tier 3 or higher, ask your physician or pharmacist whether a therapeutically equivalent generic (Tier 1 or Tier 2) is available. Switching to a generic can save hundreds or even thousands of dollars per year.

1. **Consider specialty medications carefully** -- If you take specialty medications (Tier 4 or Tier 5), the coinsurance structure means your annual drug costs can vary significantly by plan tier. The annual specialty maximum (see Section 2.7) limits your exposure, but the difference between tiers can still be substantial.

Mental Health Medications: Members who take psychiatric medications should note that these drugs are covered under the same formulary and cost-sharing structure as all other medications. Outpatient psychiatric visits are covered separately at **Unlimited, \$50 copay** (Silver Plan) for mental health therapy, and at the specialist copay rate for psychiatrist visits.

4.5 Health Savings Accounts (HSAs) and the Bronze Plan

The Bronze Plan qualifies as a High Deductible Health Plan (HDHP) under IRS guidelines, making it compatible with a Health Savings Account (HSA). An HSA is a tax-advantaged savings account that allows members to set aside pre-tax dollars to pay for qualified medical expenses, including deductibles, copays, coinsurance, and prescription drug costs.

2024 HSA Contribution Limits:

- Individual coverage: \$4,150
- Family coverage: \$8,300
- Catch-up contribution (age 55+): Additional \$1,000

Key HSA Benefits:

- Contributions are tax-deductible (or pre-tax if made through payroll)
- Earnings grow tax-free
- Withdrawals for qualified medical expenses are tax-free
- Unused funds roll over year to year (no "use it or lose it" rule)
- After age 65, funds can be withdrawn for any purpose (subject to ordinary income tax, similar to a traditional IRA)

Members who choose the Bronze Plan and contribute to an HSA can effectively reduce their net premium cost and build a reserve to cover the plan's higher deductible and out-of-pocket costs. Over time, an HSA can become a significant asset for managing both current and future healthcare expenses, including Medicare premiums in retirement.

Note: The Silver, Gold, and Platinum Plans do not qualify as HDHPs and are therefore not HSA-eligible. However, members enrolled in these plans may be eligible for a Flexible Spending Account (FSA) if offered through their employer. FSAs have different rules, including annual contribution limits and a "use it or lose it" provision.

4.6 Special Circumstances and Life Events

4.6.1 Pregnancy and Maternity Care

Members who are pregnant or planning a pregnancy should carefully evaluate their plan choice. Maternity care -- including prenatal visits, delivery, and postpartum care -- involves significant healthcare utilization concentrated in a single plan year. Under all Aetna plans, maternity care is a covered essential health benefit with no pre-existing condition waiting period (the waiting period is **None** for all conditions, including pre-existing pregnancy).

For a member who delivers in a given plan year, the combination of prenatal visits, hospital delivery, and newborn care can easily push total healthcare costs toward or beyond the in-network out-of-pocket maximum. In this scenario, the Gold or Platinum Plan's lower out-of-pocket maximum (\$5,500 or \$3,500, respectively) may result in significantly lower total annual costs compared to the Silver Plan's **\$7,500 out-of-pocket maximum**.

4.6.2 Mental and Behavioral Health Needs

Members who are currently receiving or anticipate needing mental health therapy, psychiatric care, or substance use disorder treatment should note that all Aetna plans provide robust behavioral health coverage consistent with mental health parity requirements. The Silver Plan's **mental_health_visits benefit of Unlimited, \$50 copay** for outpatient therapy means that members can access as many therapy sessions as clinically necessary without concern about visit limits.

Members with more intensive behavioral health needs -- such as those who may require Intensive Outpatient Programs (IOP), Partial Hospitalization Programs (PHP), or inpatient psychiatric care --

should consider the Gold or Platinum Plan, where the lower coinsurance rates (15% and 10%, respectively) significantly reduce the cost of these higher-intensity services.

4.6.3 Planned Surgical Procedures

Members who anticipate elective or semi-elective surgical procedures during the plan year should time their enrollment decision and procedure scheduling carefully. If a major surgery is planned, enrolling in a Gold or Platinum plan and scheduling the surgery early in the plan year can maximize the period during which the lower out-of-pocket maximum provides cost protection.

Members should also be aware of the prior authorization requirements for surgical procedures. Most inpatient surgeries and many outpatient surgical procedures require prior authorization. For imaging services such as pre-surgical MRIs, prior authorization is **Required, 3-day turnaround** for standard requests. Surgeons' offices typically manage the prior authorization process, but members are ultimately responsible for ensuring that authorization is obtained before the procedure.

4.6.4 Out-of-Network Provider Relationships

Some members have established relationships with specialists or other providers who are not in Aetna's network. If maintaining access to a specific out-of-network provider is important, members should understand the cost implications under each plan tier.

For the Silver Plan, **out-of-network coverage is 50% after \$4,000 deductible**. This means that a member who regularly sees an out-of-network specialist will first pay the \$4,000 out-of-network deductible, after which the plan pays 50% of the allowed amount. The out-of-network out-of-pocket maximum for the Silver Plan is \$15,000 -- significantly higher than the in-network maximum of \$7,500.

Members with important out-of-network provider relationships should strongly consider the Gold or Platinum Plan, which offer more favorable out-of-network cost-sharing (60% after \$3,000 deductible and 70% after \$2,000 deductible, respectively), or should explore whether their preferred providers would consider joining the Aetna network.

4.7 Plan Selection Decision Matrix

The following matrix summarizes the recommended plan tier based on the combination of health utilization level and financial risk tolerance.

	Low Risk Tolerance	Moderate Risk Tolerance	High Risk Tolerance
Low Utilization	Silver	Bronze + HSA	Bronze + HSA
Moderate Utilization	Gold	Silver	Silver or Bronze
High Utilization	Platinum	Gold	Silver
Very High Utilization	Platinum	Platinum	Gold

4.8 Summary Comparison of Key Decision Factors

Decision Factor	Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Lowest Monthly Premium	[X] Best	Good	Moderate	Highest
Lowest Deductible	--	\$2,000	\$1,000	\$500
Lowest OOP Maximum	--	\$7,500	\$5,500	\$3,500 [X] Best
HSA Eligibility	[X] Yes	No	No	No
Best for Chronic Conditions	--	Good	[X] Better	Best
Best for Catastrophic Events	Adequate	Good	Better	[X] Best
Best for Mental Health (High Use)	Adequate	Good (\$50 copay)	Better (\$40 copay)	[X] Best (\$25 copay)
Best for Rx (High Cost Drugs)	--	Moderate	Better	[X] Best
Out-of-Network Value	Limited	Moderate	Good	[X] Best

4.9 Next Steps and Enrollment Resources

Once you have reviewed this Coverage Comparison Guide and identified the plan tier that best fits your needs, the following resources are available to assist you with enrollment and plan questions:

Aetna Member Services: Call the number on the back of your member ID card, or visit www.aetna.com to access your member portal, compare plans, search for providers, and check formulary status.

Summary of Benefits and Coverage: For a standardized summary of each plan's benefits, refer to document **w14_aetna_sbc_008**. The sections **Coverage Overview, Deductibles and Out-of-Pocket Limits, and Common Medical Events** provide the key information required by federal law to be disclosed to all plan members.

Member Handbook: For detailed information on how your plan works, including claims procedures, appeals rights, and member responsibilities, refer to document **w14_aetna_member_handbook_012**, sections **Welcome and Plan Overview, How Your Plan Works, and Understanding Your Costs**.

Formulary Guide: To verify coverage and cost-sharing for your specific medications, refer to document **w14_aetna_formulary_009**, sections **Tier Structure and Cost Sharing, Generic Medications (Tier 1-2), and Specialty Medications (Tier 3-4)**.

Benefits Administrator: If you are enrolling through an employer group plan, your HR department or benefits administrator can provide plan-specific premium information, employer contribution amounts, and enrollment deadlines.

Open Enrollment Deadlines: Enrollment changes outside of the annual open enrollment period are permitted only following a qualifying life event (QLE), such as marriage, divorce, birth or adoption of a

child, loss of other coverage, or a move to a new coverage area. Contact Aetna Member Services or your benefits administrator within 30 days of a qualifying life event to make changes to your coverage.

4.10 Glossary of Key Terms

Allowed Amount: The maximum amount Aetna will pay for a covered service from a particular provider. For in-network providers, this is the negotiated rate. For out-of-network providers, this is based on Aetna's fee schedule, and the provider may bill the member for any amount above the allowed amount (balance billing).

Coinsurance: The percentage of costs the member pays after the deductible has been satisfied. For example, under the Silver Plan, the member pays 20% coinsurance and the plan pays 80% for most covered services after the \$2,000 deductible is met.

Copay: A fixed dollar amount the member pays for a covered service, regardless of the total cost of the service. Copays for primary care, specialist visits, urgent care, emergency room, and certain prescription drugs do not typically count toward the deductible under most plan designs.

Deductible: The amount the member must pay for covered services before the plan begins paying coinsurance. The Silver Plan's **in-network deductible is \$2,000** for individual coverage.

Formulary: The list of prescription drugs covered by the plan. Aetna's formulary uses a **5 tiers** structure, with different cost-sharing amounts for each tier.

Out-of-Pocket Maximum: The most a member will pay in a plan year for covered in-network services. Once this limit is reached, the plan pays 100% of covered services for the remainder of the year. The Silver Plan's **out-of-pocket maximum is \$7,500** for individual in-network coverage.

Pre-Existing Condition: A health condition that existed before the member's coverage effective date. Under all Aetna plans in this portfolio, the pre-existing condition waiting period is **None** -- coverage begins immediately on the effective date.

Prior Authorization: Approval from Aetna that must be obtained before certain services are covered. For MRI and CT scans, prior authorization is **Required, 3-day turnaround** for standard requests.

Out-of-Network: Providers who have not contracted with Aetna and are therefore not part of the plan's network. Under the Silver Plan, out-of-network coverage is **50% after \$4,000 deductible** for covered services.

This Coverage Comparison Guide is provided for informational purposes and is intended to assist members in understanding and comparing their plan options. In the event of any conflict between this guide and the official plan documents, the official plan documents govern. This guide does not constitute a contract of insurance.

For complete benefit information, please refer to your Summary of Benefits and Coverage (document w14_aetna_sbc_008), Member Handbook (document w14_aetna_member_handbook_012), and Formulary Guide (document w14_aetna_formulary_009).

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